NODUS · COMPLETE VAULT GUIDE

Academic Research

Turn a scholarly corpus into traceable ideas, debates, gaps and writing.

The Academic vault is designed for literature reviews, theses and research projects. It links every interpretation back to a work, passage and citation while supporting discovery, synthesis and long-form writing.

EDITION	English
VERSION	Nodus 4.1
UPDATED	14 August 2026
AUDIENCE	Researchers, doctoral candidates, students and evidence-led writers.

Contents

Core operation, configuration and the complete vault workflow.

PART I · FOUNDATION

Core Nodus workflow

These operating principles apply to every vault. They establish the local-first data boundary, source workflow, optional model configuration and recovery discipline used throughout this manual.

START HERE

1 Welcome to Nodus

Nodus is a local-first desktop workspace for research, teaching and study. Work is organised into focused vaults that share one private engine.

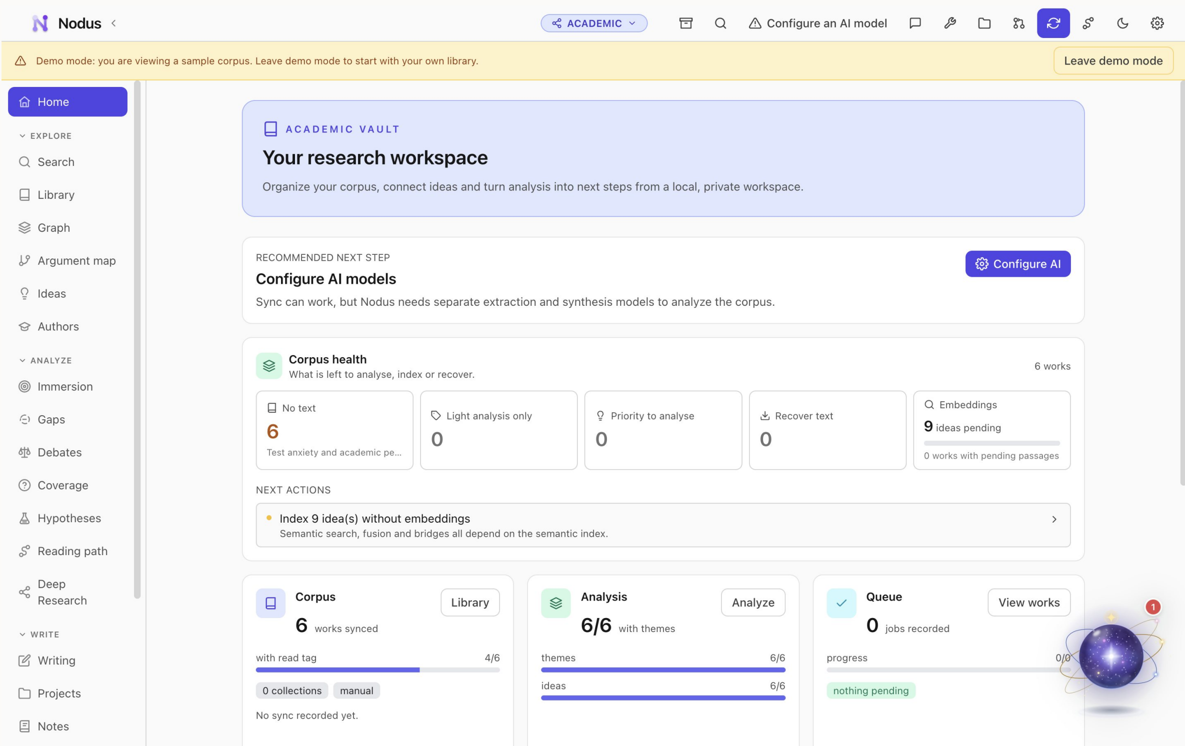
A vault changes the navigation, workflows and assistant context without changing the core promises: your database and indexes remain on your computer, accounts are optional, and AI runs only when a feature needs it and you have configured a provider.

STEP BY STEP

1. Install the current package for macOS, Windows or Linux from the Nodus release page.
2. Open Nodus and choose the interface language, Nodi style and tutorial path.
3. Create a vault for the kind of work you are doing, or load its sample vault before importing your own material.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use one vault per coherent project, course, family or dataset.
- Sample vaults are disposable and are the safest way to explore.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

START HERE

2 Create and switch vaults

Create independent workspaces and move between them without mixing their context.

The vault switcher is the boundary between projects. Each vault has its own notes, analysis and domain records, while the global Library can link the same source into compatible vaults without duplicating it.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open the vault switcher from the application header and choose New vault.

2. Name the vault, choose its type and review the short description before confirming.

3. Use the same switcher to move to another vault; Nodus restores the last open section.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use explicit names such as ‘MA thesis - memory’ or ‘Biology 2026’.
- Changing a vault type after substantial work is not a substitute for creating the correct vault.

ESSENTIALS

3 Navigation and global search

The sidebar exposes the workflow for the active vault; search retrieves material across the relevant local index.

Sections are grouped by intent - explore, analyse and write, or organisation and assessment. Search combines exact keyword matching with semantic retrieval when an embedding model is configured, and results preserve links to their source.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a section in the left sidebar; the active section is highlighted.
2. Open Search and enter at least two meaningful characters or a natural-language concept.
3. Filter or inspect a result, then follow its source link to the document, record, person or note.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Search for concepts, not only exact titles.
- Rebuild an index from Settings if recently imported content does not appear.

ESSENTIALS

4 Library, sources and reader

Keep preserved originals beside clean reading copies, citations, highlights and extracted evidence.

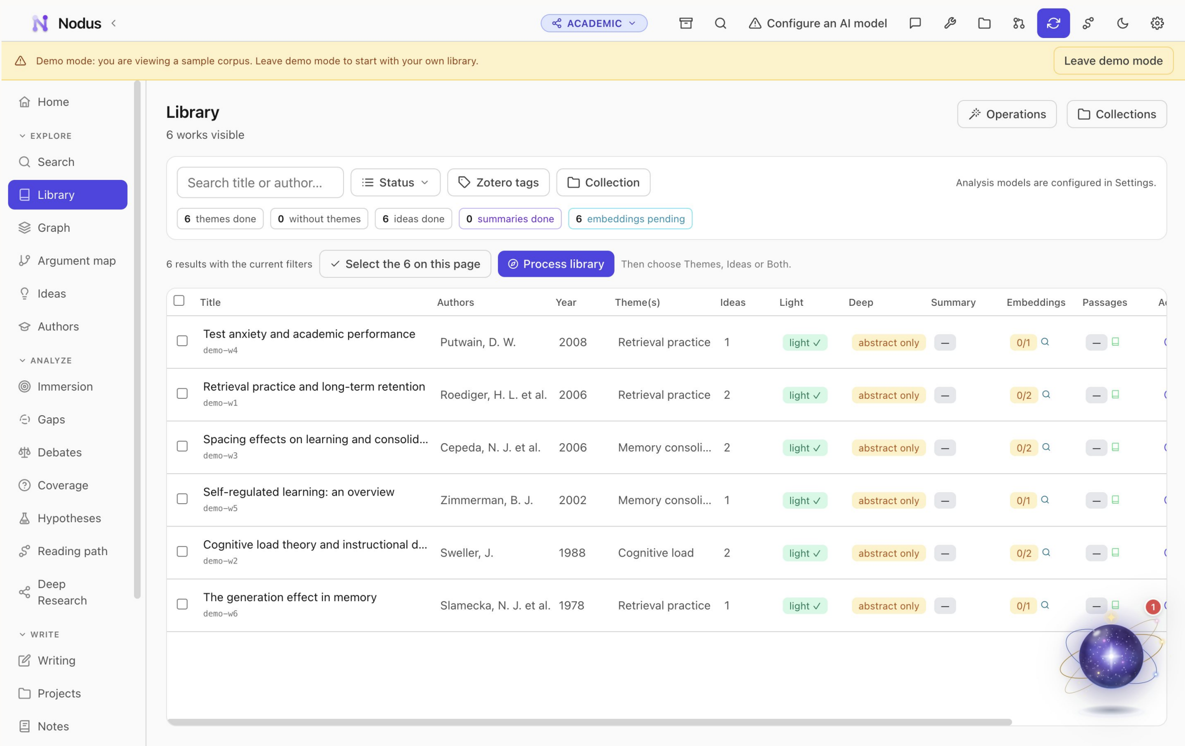
The cross-vault Library can mirror Zotero, import RIS, BibTeX and CSL JSON, or accept files directly. Nodus preserves the original attachment and creates searchable derivatives. Compatible sources can be linked to several vaults without copying the original.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Library and add a local file, import bibliographic data or connect Zotero.
2. Place the item in a collection and add useful tags; wait for extraction and indexing to finish.
3. Open the item, choose the clean reading copy or preserved original, then highlight passages and link the item into the active vault.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the preserved original for page-accurate verification.
- Treat automatically extracted text and metadata as a first pass that may need correction.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

CONFIGURATION

5 AI providers and task models

Bring your own cloud key or use compatible local models, with a different model for each task.

Provider keys are stored in the operating-system keychain. Nodus distinguishes deterministic local tools from model-assisted features and shows when content will leave the device. Model preferences can mix providers by extraction, chat, writing and report tasks.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, then Providers, and configure a cloud key or local endpoint.
2. Use the validation action before saving, then open Models.
3. Assign a suitable model to each task and run a small test on sample content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A local model improves privacy but may require more memory and time.
- Review every generated claim against its linked evidence.

CONFIGURATION

6 Privacy, backups and recovery

Protect local work with a verified backup and understand exactly when network services are used.

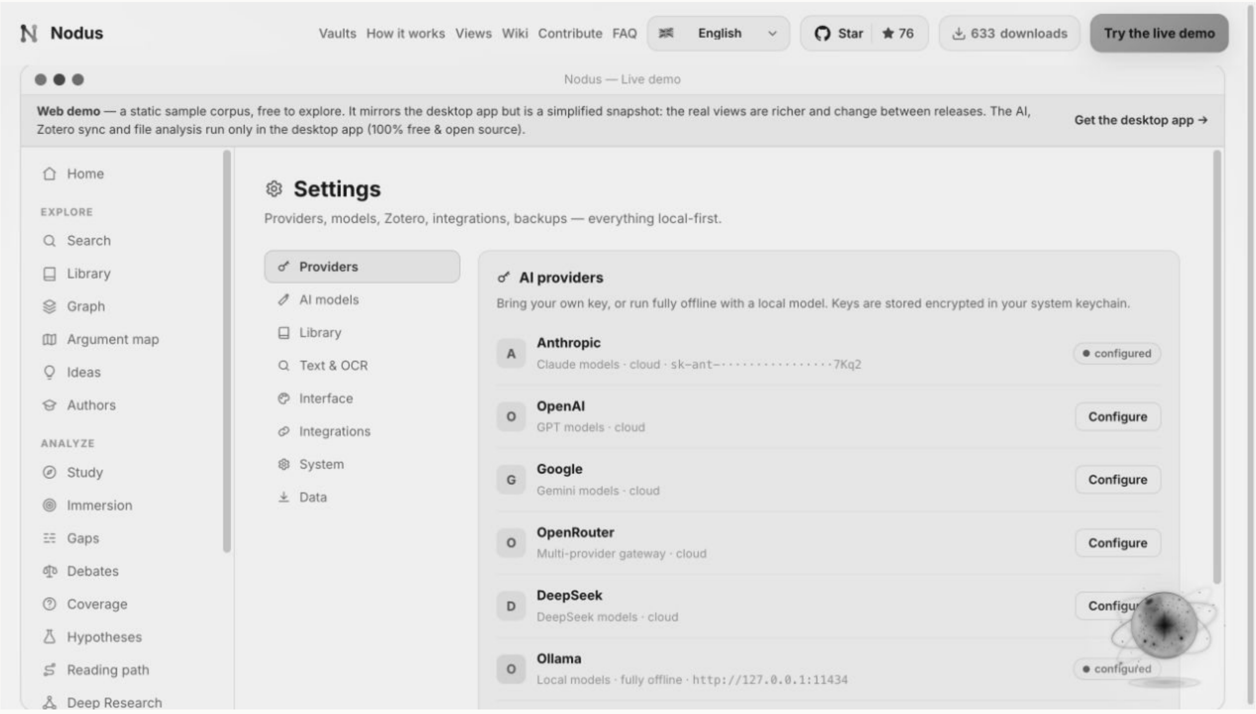
Vault databases, indexes and library files are local by default. Backups can include all vaults and the shared Library. Nodus reports backup health and creates protected recovery copies before major migrations.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, choose a backup destination and enable automatic backups.
2. Run a manual backup, then use verification to confirm that its manifest and files are readable.
3. Review the privacy notice for each optional online feature before sending content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Store backups on a different physical device or a trusted encrypted location.
- Do not treat sync as a backup; keep versioned recovery copies.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

CONFIGURATION

7 Toolkit and integrations

Convert, protect, translate, OCR and present documents, or connect Zotero, Word, MCP clients and Nodus Server.

Toolkit utilities are available across vaults. Integrations remain optional: Zotero supplies bibliographic material, Word uses grounded Nodus context, MCP exposes approved local tools, and Nodus Server publishes a selected copy rather than the source vault.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Toolkit and choose Convert, Protect, Translate, OCR Workspace or PDF Presenter.
2. Select a file from disk or a compatible vault source and review the output options.
3. For an integration, enable only the connector you need and test it with non-sensitive sample content first.

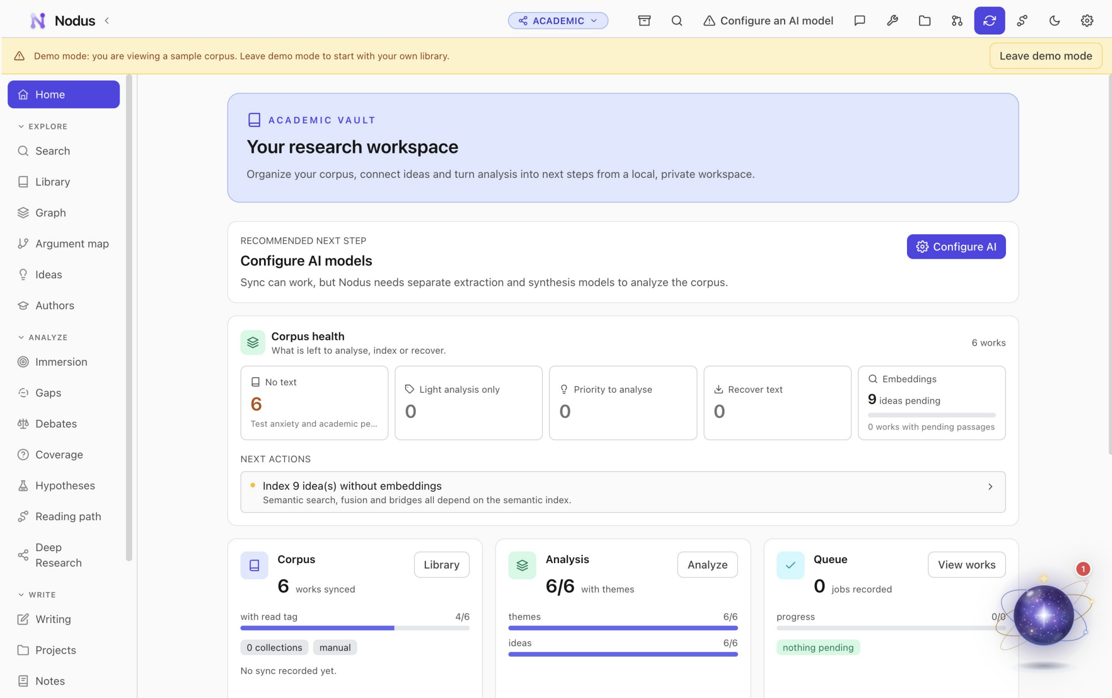
GOOD PRACTICE

- Permanent redaction in Protect is local and irreversible in the exported copy.
- Published server spaces should contain only material intended for their readers.

PART II · VAULT GUIDE

Complete Academic Research workflow

The Academic vault is designed for literature reviews, theses and research projects. It links every interpretation back to a work, passage and citation while supporting discovery, synthesis and long-form writing.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

ORIENTATION

1 Home and research status

Read the health of the corpus and jump to the most useful next action.

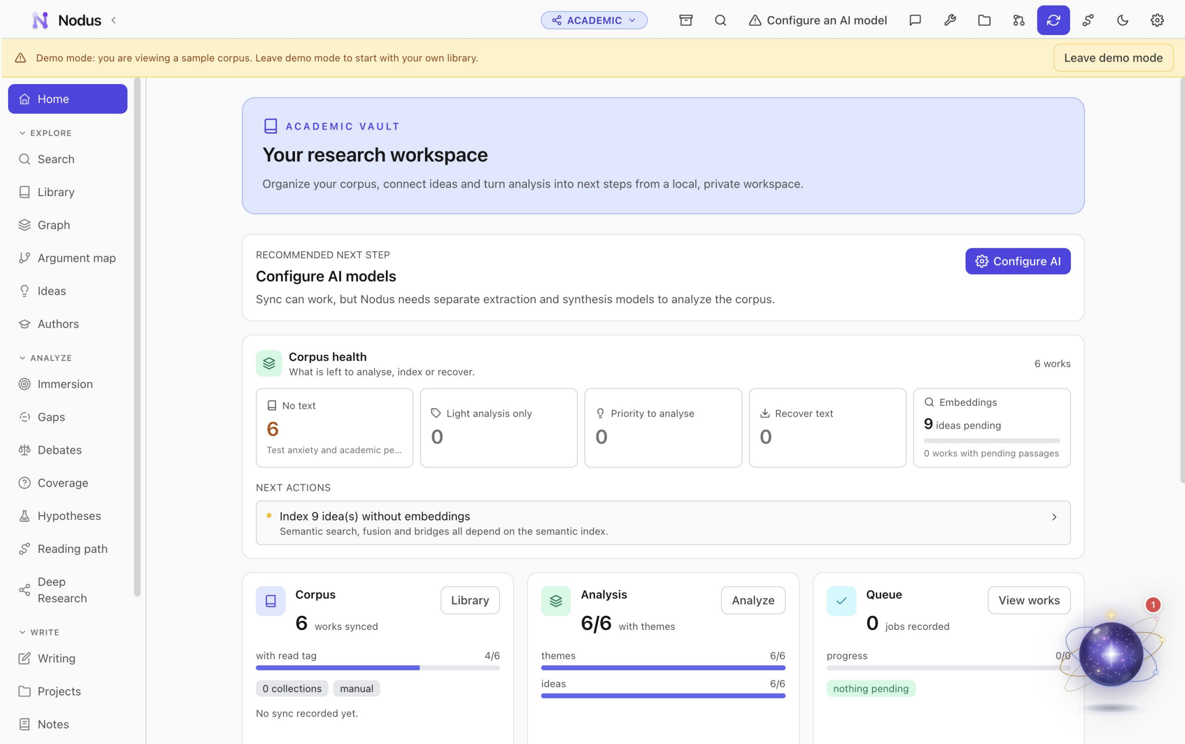
Home combines corpus totals, recent activity, analysis progress and shortcuts. It is a dashboard, not a separate store: every card opens the underlying view.

STEP BY STEP

1. Check the corpus and idea counts after importing sources.
2. Review processing or coverage warnings before starting synthesis.
3. Use Recent activity or a recommended next step to resume work.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A small, carefully scoped corpus often produces better analysis than an indiscriminate import.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

EXPLORE

2 Search

Search works, ideas and authors with exact and semantic retrieval.

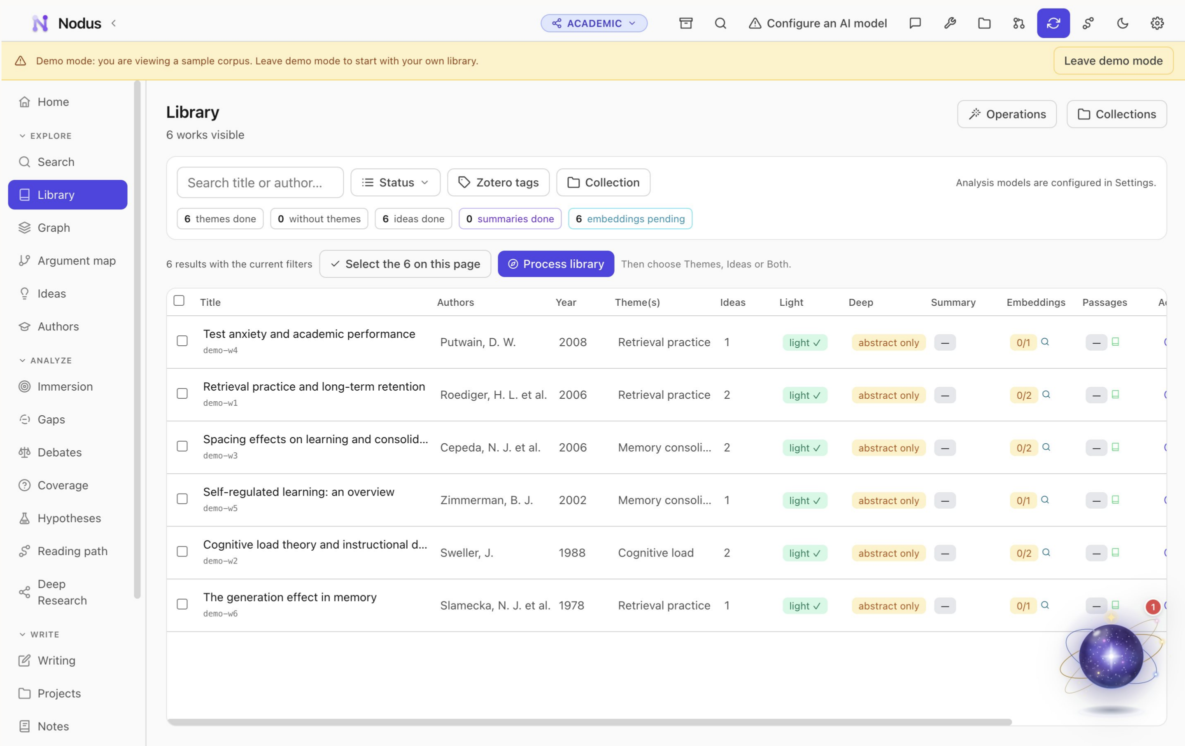
Results preserve the entity type and source context. Semantic search is valuable when the wording in the corpus differs from the question.

STEP BY STEP

1. Enter a title fragment, author, quotation or concept.
2. Compare idea, author and work results rather than opening only the first hit.
3. Open the source record and verify the relevant passage.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use filters or a narrower query when the corpus spans unrelated fields.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

EXPLORE

3 Library and corpus

Build the evidence base from Zotero or local sources and decide what belongs in this vault.

The Library stores bibliographic metadata, attachments and searchable text. Linking an item to the vault places it in the academic corpus; removing the link does not destroy the global source.

STEP BY STEP

1. Import or sync sources and inspect title, authors, year, identifiers and attachment status.
2. Link relevant items into the vault and organise them with collections and tags.
3. Open the reader to highlight, annotate and confirm page mappings.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Resolve duplicate records before analysis so one source is not counted twice.

EXPLORE

4 Knowledge graph

See themes, ideas and typed relations as an interactive research map.

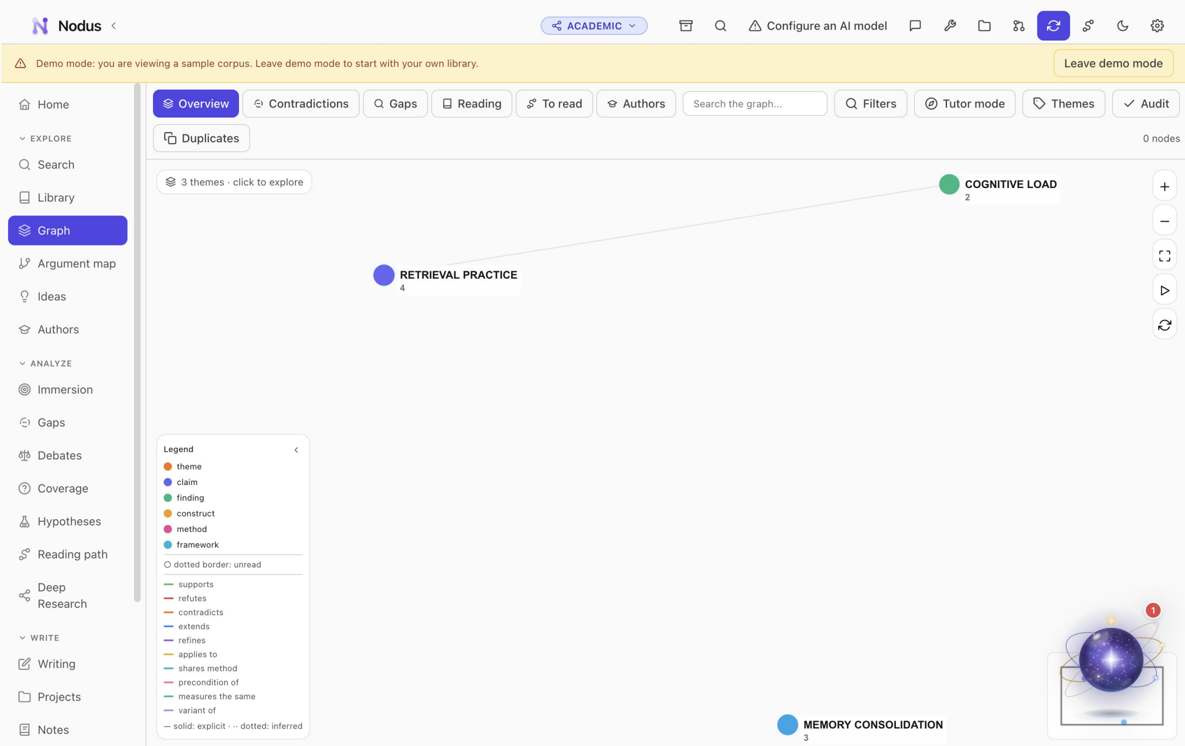
Nodes represent research entities and edges express relations such as support, contrast or application. Presets and filters help move from a corpus overview to a focused question.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a graph preset or filter by theme, author or relation type.
2. Select a node to inspect its evidence and immediate neighbourhood.
3. Open a connected source before accepting the interpretation represented by an edge.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use the graph to generate questions, not as proof by itself.



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EXPLORE

5 Argument map

Arrange claims and evidence into an explicit structure for a paper or chapter.

Argument maps make the role of each claim visible: thesis, support, objection, reply or evidence. Connections remain inspectable and can be reorganised as the argument develops.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create or open a map for one defensible research question.
2. Add claims from extracted ideas or write a clearly labelled working claim.
3. Connect supporting evidence, objections and replies, then check every leaf node for a source.

GOOD PRACTICE

- If a claim has no evidence or inferential bridge, the map has found a writing problem early.

EXPLORE

6 Ideas

Review extracted claims, findings, methods and definitions with their exact evidence.

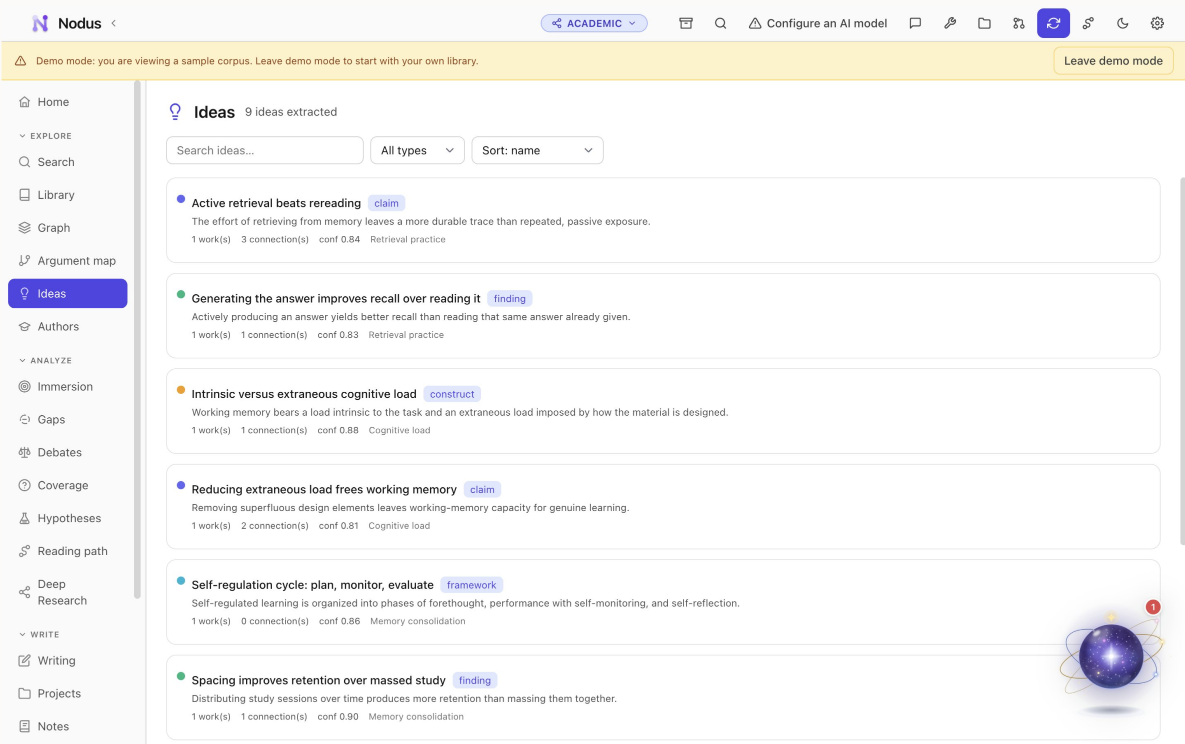
Ideas are structured interpretations of passages, not detached summaries. Each one records its type, source and supporting excerpt and can participate in themes and relations.

STEP BY STEP

1. Filter by type or theme and open an idea.
2. Read the verbatim evidence and page reference.
3. Correct the label or relation when the extraction overstates the source.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Prefer concise idea labels that make one testable or attributable claim.



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EXPLORE

7 Authors

Compare an author’s works, ideas and position within the corpus.

Author profiles aggregate only what the active corpus supports. They help distinguish an author’s documented stance from a general reputation.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open an author and review works included in the corpus.
2. Compare their idea set and position map with adjacent authors.
3. Return to source passages before describing disagreement or influence.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Do not infer an author’s complete position from an incomplete corpus.

ANALYSE

8 Study tools

Create flashcards and Socratic routes grounded in the research corpus.

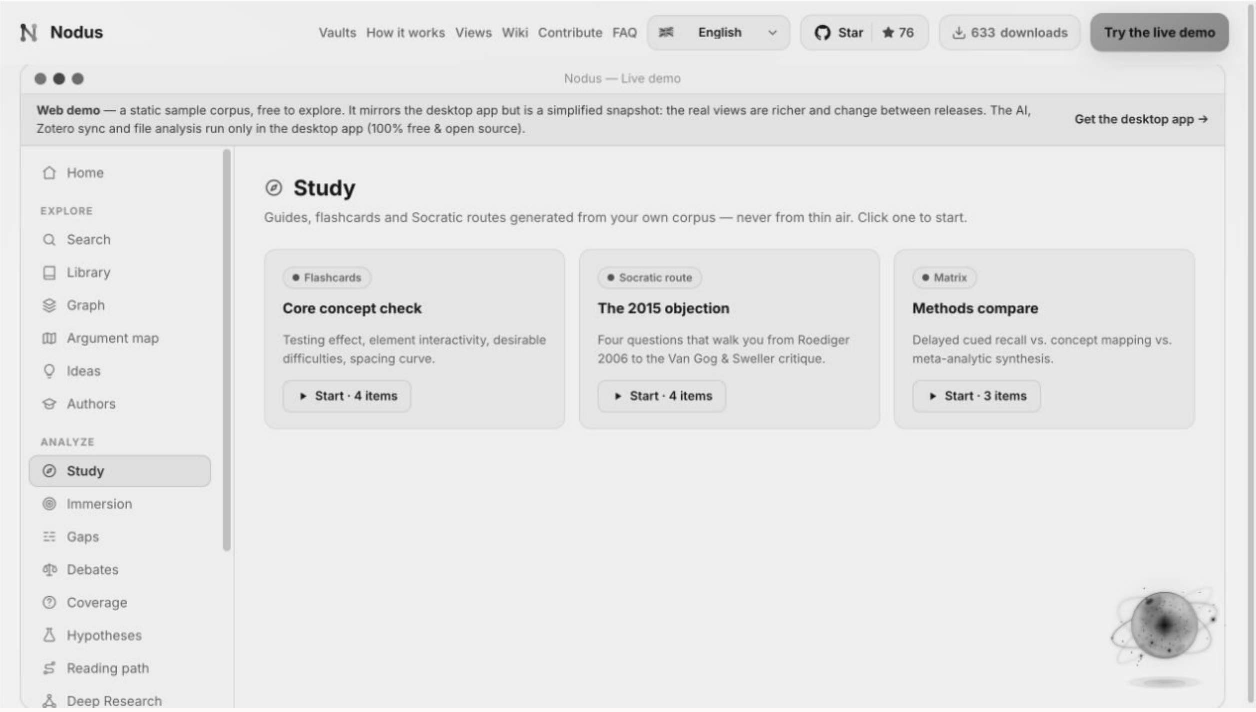
Academic study tools support comprehension before synthesis. Generated questions retain references and results feed spaced review where available.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a theme or selected sources.
2. Open a flashcard deck or Socratic route and answer before revealing guidance.
3. Mark confidence honestly and revisit the cited passage for weak answers.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Retrieval practice is most useful when you produce an answer before checking it.



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ANALYSE

9 Immersion

Follow a guided, audio-capable journey through a central research question.

Immersion sequences evidence stations, commentary and a final check. It is designed for focused orientation, not as a replacement for reading the sources.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose an available immersion and review its duration and sources.

2. Move through each station, pausing to inspect quotations and context.

3. Complete the final question and save follow-up notes.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use headphones for audio, but keep citations visible for verification.

ANALYSE

10 Research gaps

Distinguish unanswered questions from places where the current corpus is merely incomplete.

A gap records available evidence, what remains missing and candidate directions. It is a research prompt whose strength depends on corpus coverage.

STEP BY STEP

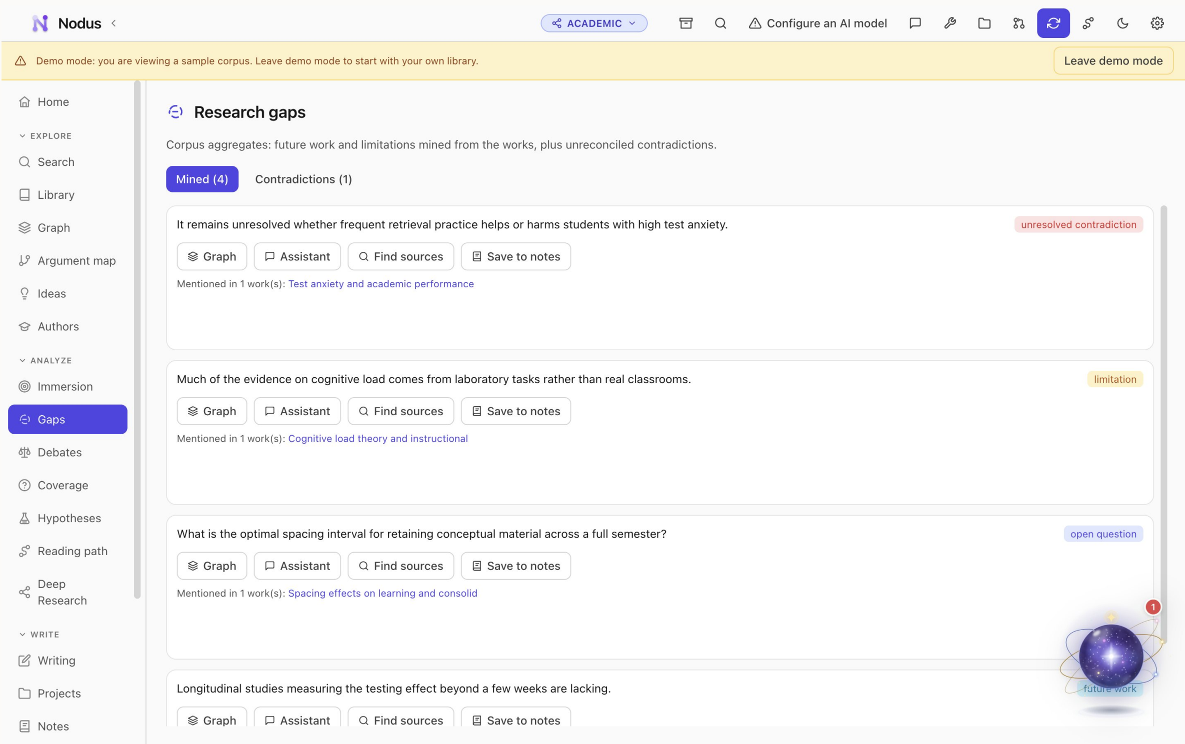
1. Open a gap and read the evidence already present.

2. Examine what would close the gap and whether the scope is explicit.

3. Search external catalogues for candidate sources, then update the gap after importing them.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Phrase conclusions as ‘gap in this corpus’ until a broader search supports a field-level claim.



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ANALYSE

11 Debates

Compare opposed or qualified positions without flattening their evidence.

Debate views group claims by stance and show the works behind them. Nuance, boundary conditions and methodological differences can matter more than a simple pro/con split.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open a debate and identify the precise proposition under dispute.
2. Compare the strongest evidence on each side and inspect source passages.
3. Record qualifications or a synthesis that explains when each position holds.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Do not count papers as votes; compare relevance, method and evidential strength.

ANALYSE

12 Coverage analysis

Measure how well the corpus supports important themes and questions.

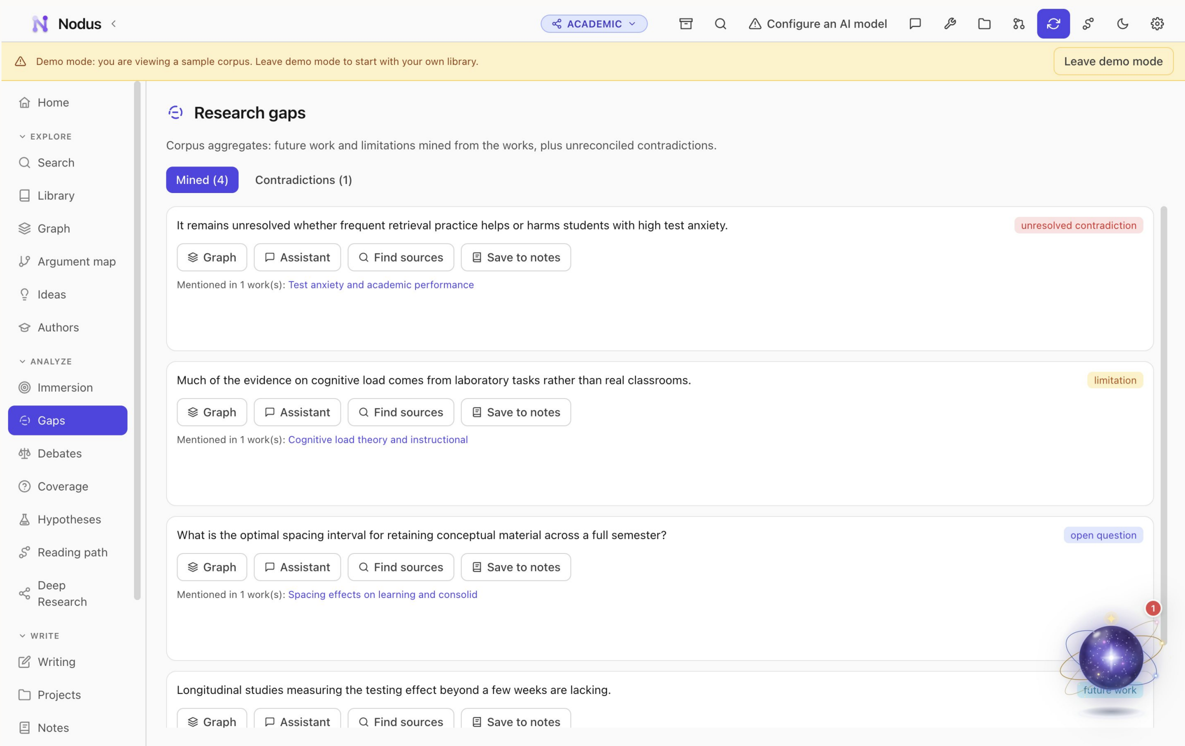
Coverage highlights overrepresented and under-supported areas. It helps prioritise reading and makes literature-review boundaries explicit.

STEP BY STEP

1. Select a theme or question and inspect its linked works and ideas.
2. Review missing perspectives, dates, methods or populations.
3. Turn a weakness into a targeted search query or reading task.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Coverage is relative to your project question, not a universal completeness score.



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ANALYSE

13 Hypotheses

Turn patterns in the corpus into falsifiable propositions and test designs.

A hypothesis combines a statement, supporting ideas, risks and a proposed test. Keeping these fields separate prevents plausible speculation from masquerading as evidence.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a hypothesis from a documented pattern or unresolved debate.

2. Attach supporting and contradicting ideas.

3. Write a result that would falsify it and outline the minimum viable test.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A useful hypothesis can fail; avoid wording that explains every possible outcome.

ANALYSE

14 Reading paths

Order sources and ideas into a purposeful route through the corpus.

A reading path can introduce foundations, move through a debate and finish with open questions. Each stop should have a reason, not simply a rank.

STEP BY STEP

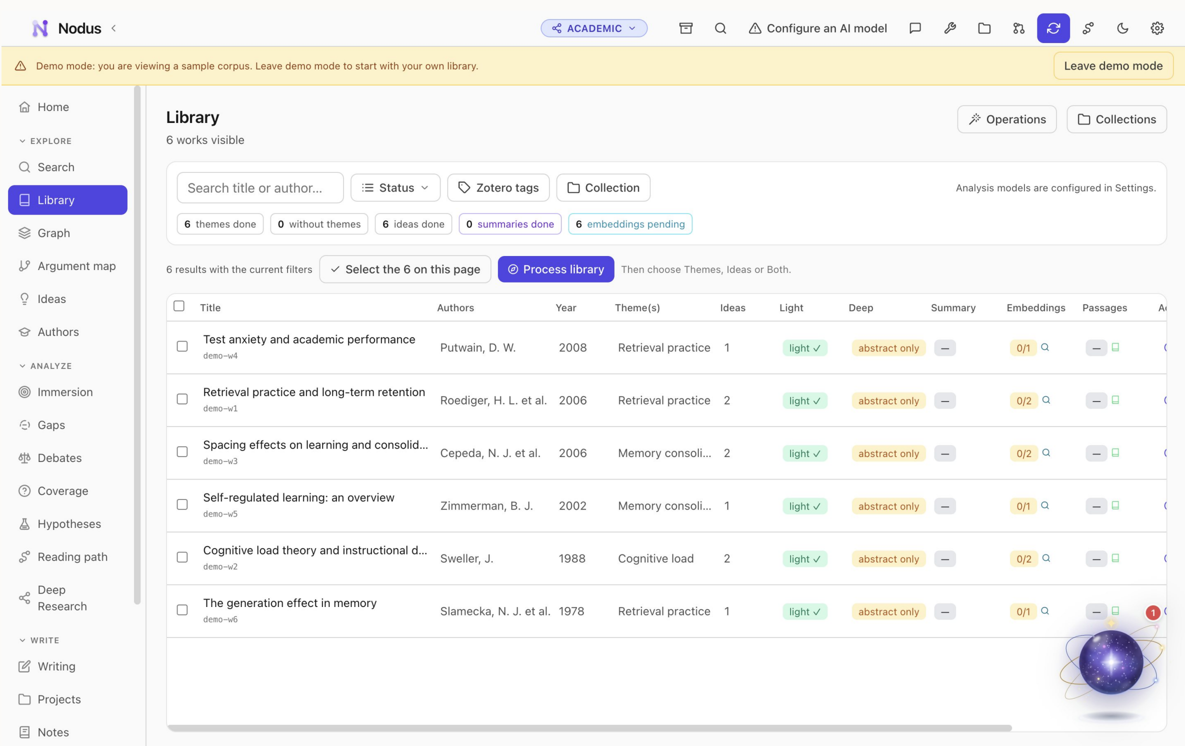
1. Choose a learning or research objective.

2. Sequence foundational, contrasting and advanced sources.

3. Add a short purpose to each stop and revise the path as the corpus changes.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep paths short enough to finish; branch optional depth instead of making one endless list.



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ANALYSE

15 Deep Research

Generate a long-form, citation-rich report from the whole scoped corpus.

Deep Research runs as a queued job, synthesises selected material and produces a structured report whose citations can be opened. It should be treated as an auditable draft.

STEP BY STEP

1. Write a bounded question, choose the corpus scope and start the job.

2. Monitor the queue and open the report when processing completes.

3. Audit important claims through their citations, annotate problems and export only after review.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A precise question and curated scope matter more than maximum corpus size.

WRITE

16 Writing workshop

Draft with corpus context, linked evidence and verifiable citations.

Writing keeps drafts beside the knowledge graph. Assistance can compose or revise selected text while preserving source links; the author remains responsible for the argument and final wording.

STEP BY STEP

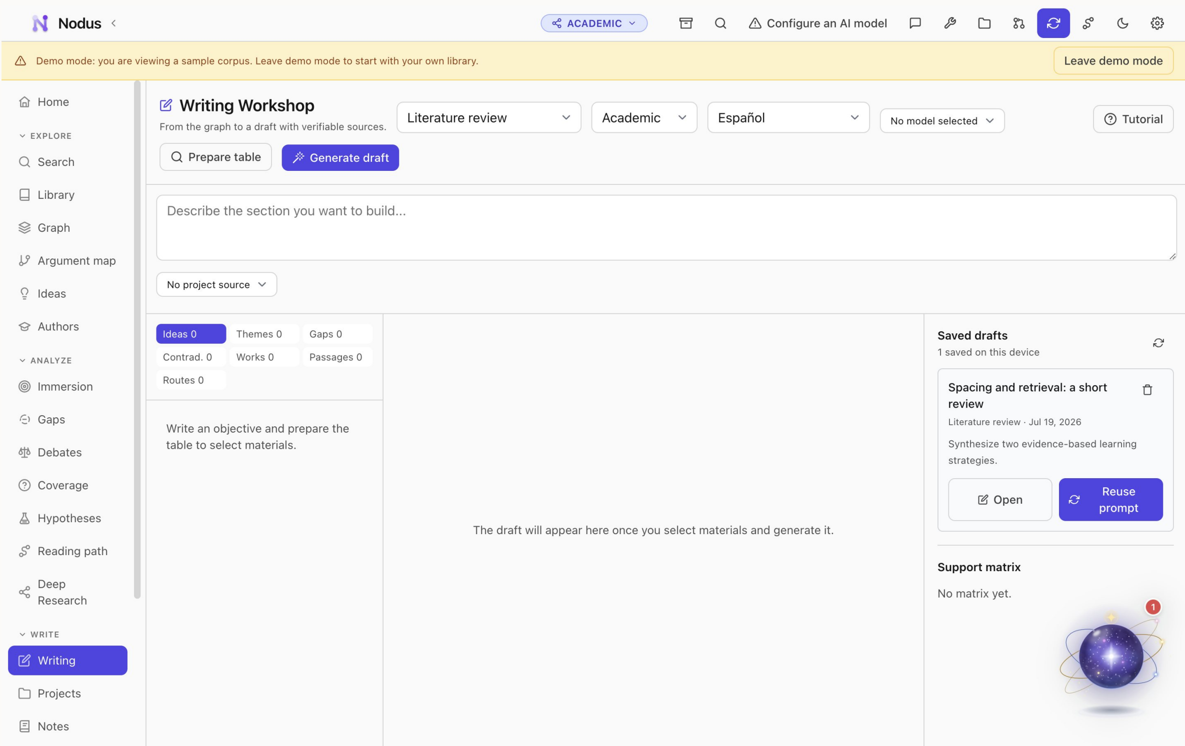
1. Create a project and draft, then define its purpose and audience.

2. Insert or compose a cited sentence from selected evidence.

3. Open each citation, revise the prose in your own voice and export the finished document.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Never accept a citation because its formatting looks plausible; verify that it supports the sentence.



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WRITE

17 Projects and notes

Keep manuscripts, working notes and source-linked observations organised.

Projects group drafts and supporting context. Notes capture thoughts that may link to ideas, sources or other notes without forcing them into the formal argument too early.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a project for a paper, chapter or review.
2. Use folders and descriptive titles for working notes.
3. Link notes to the relevant source or idea and promote mature material into a draft.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Separate source notes, synthesis notes and draft prose to preserve provenance.

CONFIGURE

18 Academic settings

Control Zotero, extraction, graph behaviour, models, Word, MCP and backups.

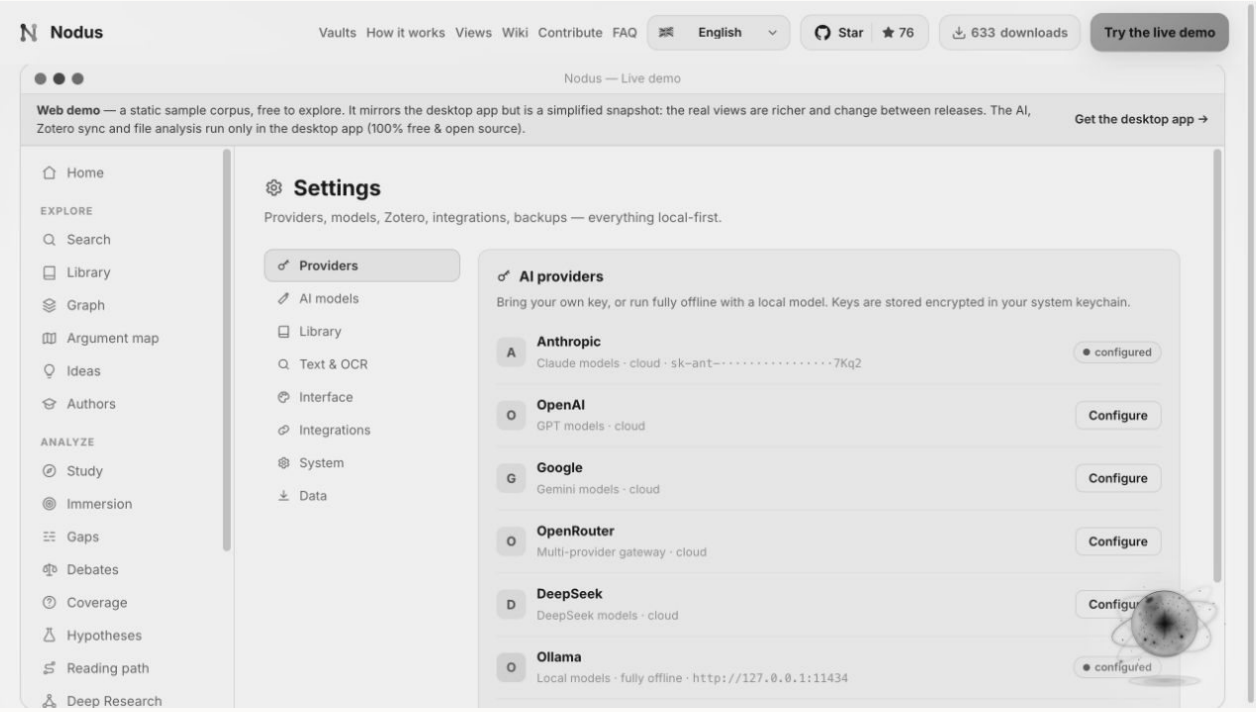
Academic settings expose the common provider and system controls plus research-specific integrations and extraction preferences.

STEP BY STEP

1. Configure Zotero or direct imports and verify Library status.
2. Review text extraction, OCR, citation style and per-task model choices.
3. Enable Word, MCP or publishing only when needed, then verify backup health.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Change one pipeline setting at a time and test it on a known source.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

REFERENCE

Completion checklist

- The vault scope and name match the project.
- Sources or records have preserved originals and reviewed metadata.
- Generated interpretations have been checked against their evidence.
- Optional providers and integrations use only the intended data.
- Exports have been proofread in their final format.
- A recent backup has been created and verified.

This manual documents the stable English workflow represented in Nodus 4.1. Interface details may evolve between releases; the in-app privacy notice and release notes govern the exact behaviour of the installed version.